Only the Shah himself showed any pleasure or emotion. ‘His Majesty led the way into the palace and gardens,’ wrote Major Hough. ‘The former were so much dilapidated after the lapse of thirty years that the old man wept, while he explained to his grandsons and family the state of its former splendour.’ As he mounted the familiar staircase to the upper wards of the palace and could see Kabul spread out below him, his spirits rose as he realised that his dream, thwarted for three decades, had finally been fulfilled: ‘Ascending the great staircase, the Shah ran with childish eagerness from one small chamber to another of the well-remembered abode of royalty, deploring aloud the neglect and damage which was everywhere visible, and particularly lamented the removal of the panels of mirror from the sheesh mahal.’[110]

But, for all the complaints, Shah Shuja was happy. Finally, he was home.